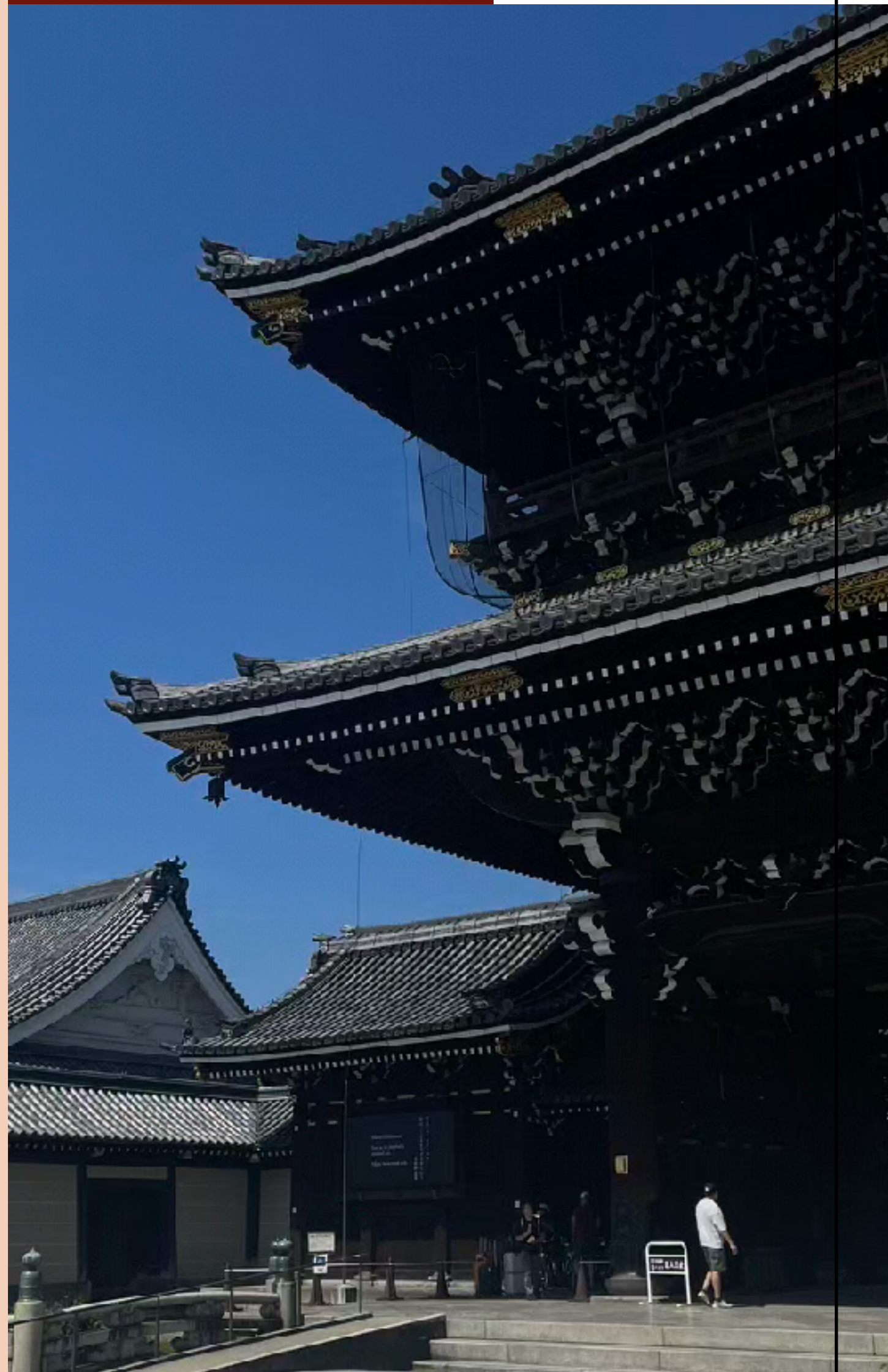


19th August, 2026

Ethics & Social Responsibility

Lecture One.

Noemi Chaw



if you need help,



Contact Information

Reach Out

if you have any questions, uncertainties, or stress factors

EMAIL: noemichaw@smu.edu.sg

TA: Jordan (jordan.ang.2023@socsc.smu.edu.sg)

Note

to ensure fairness, all questions relating to the course's content will be responded to during class.

‘lesson plan’



- Getting to know you
- How we will study ethics
- Relevance of ethics today
- Day-to-day ethical dilemmas
- Best methods & tips
- The first of several ethical theories

INTRODUCTION

getting to know you

How many of you
bid for this class
with a
friend/group?

well, I hope you have made
a new friend or two.

COURSE DESIGN

how we will study ethics

**The
Study
Of
ETHICS
&
SOCIAL
RESPONSIBILITY**

an overview

I	<u>An Overview of the Contemporary Relevance of Ethics:</u> how ethical dilemmas exist in our daily lives
II	<u>Ethical Theories (Part I):</u> Utilitarianism; Egoism; Kantian Ethics; Aristotelian Virtue Ethics; Sandel Ethics; Confucianism
III	<u>Application of the Ethical Theories:</u> in matters of environmentalism and sustainable living; advertising and marketing; technology; crime; current affairs; and more.
IV	<u>Ethical Theories (Part II):</u> Distributive Justice (Rawls; Aristotle; and Nozick); The Market System; and Singer's Ethics
V	<u>Application of the Ethical Theories:</u> in matters of (international) business ethics and corruption; corporate social responsibility; ethics in the workplace; and more

Course Objectives

one

Establish a firm
foundation of key
ethical theories

two

Identify ethical and
social responsibility
dilemmas in society
and life generally

three

Apply the ethical
theories to ethical and
social responsibility
dilemmas in decision-
making

Assessment Methods

Class Participation	20%
Mid-Term Test	15%
Group Project - Oral Presentation	15%
Final Examination	50%

assessment method

Class Participation

—

one

assessment method one



Class Participation

How am I graded on class participation?

Your grade is made up of two components.

1. Attendance (35%)
2. Contributions to Class Discussion (65%)
 - This is further broken down into:
 - A. Quantity (25% of total)
 - B. Quality (40% of total)

* But do not overlook the importance of quantity; because you are graded relative to your classmates.

assessment method one

A large orange circle is positioned on the left side of the slide, containing the text 'Class Participation'.

Class Participation

1. Attendance

- Mandatory for all seminars
- Unexcused absences will adversely affect your class participation grade.
- Subject to exigent circumstances, please email me (noemichaw@smu.edu.sg), copying the TA, *before* the start of the seminar in relation to your absence.

assessment method one



Class Participation

What are valid excuses for absences from class?

- Ill and:
 - covered by a medical certificate for the day of the class; or
 - covered by a doctor's memo obtained during a visit as soon as practicable during or after class.
- Overseas for SMU-sanctioned and official school activities (incl. representing the university for competitions; and delays caused by third-parties in completing exchange programmes)

a non-exhaustive list of examples

assessment method one



Class Participation

What are NOT valid excuses for absences from class?

- Attending concerts
- Celebrating birthdays (whether yours or that of family members)
- Traveling
- Oversleeping/forgetting to attend

a non-exhaustive list of examples

Class Participation

2. Participations

- Contribution to the discussion through *comments* and *questions*
- Engage with and build on other contributions,
 - *without repeating points*; and
 - *in a respectful manner*.
- Use this as an opportunity to show your preparation
- Leverage your pre-existing knowledge and experience

* This class is meant to be discussive – there will be a lot of discussions and as we try to debate what is ethical and what is not, and why.

assessment method one



Class Participation

What if I hate / am not comfortable with speaking in public?

Here's an option for you.

- During each week's group presentation, a Google Doc will be circulated by your TA for you to insert your questions for the group.
- Regardless of whether or not the group answers your question(s) (in light of available time), all questions asked will count towards your class participation component grades.

assessment method

Mid-Term Examination

—

two

Mid-Term Examination

Why do we have a Mid-Term Examination?

Because of the Final Examination.

- The format of the Final Examination may be foreign to a lot of you.
- The Mid-Term Examination is intended to be an opportunity for you to familiarize yourself with what is expected of you during the Final Examination.



Mid-Term Examination

The Mid-Term Test is NOT to penalise or stress you.

- To give both you and me a gauge of your understanding of the course material thus far:
 - particularly, your understanding of the ethical theories; and
 - your ability to apply them.

You are being tested on your ability to apply, not memorize.

- Open-Book Examination
 - Students may bring printed materials to reference during the examination.
 - No reference to electronic materials, or materials stored on any electronic or analog devices are permitted.

Mid-Term Examination

Format of the Mid-Term Examination

Hypothetical

- A hypothetical is a write-up presenting a hypothetical scenario/story that contains various ethical dilemmas.

Mid-Term Examination

Format of the Mid-Term Examination

Hypothetical

- You will receive a set of instructions that you must fully satisfy. For example:
 1. Identify all the ethical issues raised by the facts.
 2. Evaluate the ethicality of at least five ethical issues you identified in Part 1:
 - A. for each issue, provide an in-depth, critical, and balanced analysis; and
 - B. you should use at least two of the most compelling and relevant ethical theories to each ethical issue under consideration.
 3. Following your analysis, decide whether the relevant parties had acted ethically.
 4. In light of your analysis, provide practical recommendations as to what could have been done differently or improved upon to address the issues that you have examined in Part 2.

assessment method

Group Project

three

assessment method three



Group Project

- 8 Groups of 6
 - Students may form groups on their own, or opt to be assigned to a group.
 - A representative of the group should email the TA by Wednesday, 26 January 2026 at 12pm with a finalised list of group members.
 - Please list the full names of each group member, *per* your registered name on the SMU system.
 - Please copy all group members in the email.
- **Note:** Groupings are subject to change for reasons including, insufficient or too many groups of a certain number or type.

assessment method three



Group Project

- Selection of Topics
 - In class during the break in week 2 (26 August 2026)
 - Once all groupings are finalised, inform the TA of your group's preferred presentation during the break.
 - Topics will be assigned on a first-come, first-serve basis.

assessment method three



Group Project

Format of the Group Presentation

Oral Presentation + Q&A

Every group member must present

- 20-minute oral presentation on ethical dilemmas arising in the area covered in class for the week
- Answer 8 questions from the class regarding your presented content.

Optional

- Use of written materials, slides, and/or other materials is optional.

assessment method three



Group Project

Content of the Group Presentation

any ethical dilemma related to that week's content

- For example, the group presenting in Week 3 can select any case study/ethical dilemma relating to “environmental ethics and sustainable living” (*ie*, the topic for the week).

assessment method three



Group Project

Content of the Group Presentation

*while your presentation can take any form/style,
you **must**:*

- provide necessary context and background to ensure that the class is cognizant of the facts and why it presents an ethical dilemma;
- state clearly which ethical theories will be applied and why those ethical theories (as opposed to others were selected);
- apply the selected ethical theories to determine whether the act/omission is ethical; and
- consider the shortcomings of the applied ethical theories.

assessment method three



Group Project

Grading of the Group Presentation

what are you graded on?

Performance is graded collectively, subject to other compelling circumstances, in consideration of:

- clarity
- accuracy of content
- appropriateness of ethical theories applied
- breadth and depth of analysis
- correctness and relevancy of your answers to your classmates' questions



Group Project

Guidance for Group Projects

*to ensure fairness, there are
no private consultations*

But, if you are concerned about whether your group is on the right track (in terms of application of the ethical theories), you may drop me an email by 3pm on the Wednesday before your presentation to ask up to 4 non-substantive questions:

- *ie*, the group presenting in Week 3 should send in their email by Wednesday on Week 2.

Answers provided will only express whether the group is largely on track and/or guiding in nature. Specific, substantive answers (eg, on accuracy of content, application of theory, style, which parts of the presentation is on track or not, etc.) will not be provided.

assessment method three



Group Project

Guidance for Group Projects

*to ensure fairness, there are
no private consultations*

But, if you are concerned about whether your group is on the right track (in terms of application of the ethical theories), you may drop me an email by 3pm on the Wednesday before your presentation to ask up to 4 non-substantive questions:

- *ie*, the group presenting in Week 3 should send in their email by Wednesday on Week 2.

Questions should be sent in earliest one week before your presentation. For example, if the group presenting in Week 10 sends in their questions in Week 5, they will not receive a response until Week 9.

assessment method

Final Examination

—

four

Final Examination

Mandatory and inescapable.

- More information will be share about the final examination in due course.
- Till then, focus on:
 - understanding the ethical theories (including their limitations); and
 - how to apply them.

*treat others like
you'd want to be treated*

- Be kind; respectful; and professional
- Please think before speaking
- Stay on topic
- Be forgiving of others' mistakes
- Remember, you don't get extra credit for eviscerating the opinions and thoughts of others

one last thing before we start

ETIQUETTE

WE HAVE TO STUDY ETHICS

how should I study ethics?

what do I do before class?

No Mandatory Readings for this Class

But, if you want to read ahead,
reading lists will be uploaded for particularly important/content-heavy topics.

However, these are not compulsory and not doing them will not be fatal to your grade.

what do I do during class?

Pay Attention.

Why aren't the slides provided before class?

It is scientifically proven that giving students slides/materials before class result in them being less likely to pay attention in class.

Also, the slides contain the answers/guidance to answer questions. Thus, giving the slides prior to class would be tantamount to giving you the answer; defeating the purpose of class participation and discussion.

what do I do during class?

Take Notes

What should I be taking notes of?

You will be given the slides presented in class thereafter. So, there is no need to copy down what is on the slides. Instead, focus on jotting down important discussions/tips/pointers that are given during the class. This will enhance your own notes later.

what do I do after class?

Review the Slides & Make Your Own Notes

Why Am I Making my Own Notes?

The Mid-Term and Final Examinations are open-book examinations (*ie*, you can bring in your notes into the examination). Reviewing in-class content and slides to make your own notes will help you familiarize yourself with the content and with the structure of your own notes.

TLDR: It will help you excel during the examinations.

if all else fails?

**Paying Attention in Class AND Relying on Your Notes
Gives You Sufficient Material to Get at Least a B+
(if not higher)**

(If you totally understand everything that is in the slides, and how to apply them well)

IMPORTANCE OF ETHICS

why are we studying ethics?

“i think that’s right...”

01 | **How have you decided whether something is right or wrong?**

- What does your “conscience” say?

02 | **But, is there ever one right answer?**

- Stealing a loaf of bread to feed your hungry children
- Cheating in an examination that everyone else is cheating in
- Littering

but, ethics is NOT:

A collection of opinions.

- It does not change with the times.

A person's beliefs and preferences.

Ethical Dilemmas in Your Lives

What are some ethical dilemmas that you face in your daily lives?

What about during your internships?

Please share your personal experiences.

UTILITARIANISM

“one for all”?

an overview on utilitarianism

What do you know about utilitarianism?

A teleological theory.

- The ethicality of an action/behaviour/thought is determined with reference to the purpose it serves/consequence it produces, rather than its cause.
- In other words, “the rightness of actions is determined solely by the amount of good consequences they produce” (Boatright).
- The (virtue of the) ends, justify the means.

Utilitarianism is the most prominent teleological theory.

in summary,

Utilitarianism asks,
“what actions are right?”

based on the consequences it generates

what does this mean?

“An action is right if and only if it produces the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone”

distinct theses of utilitarian theory

one

CONSEQUENTIALISM

two

HEDONISM

three

MAXIMALISM

four

UNIVERSALISM

what are these?

these are four, conjunctive yet distinct features/aspects of utilitarianism

distinct theses of utilitarian theory



theses of utilitarian theory

one

Consequentialism

Consider the consequences.

- Whether an action is right is determined by its consequences:
 - whether it achieved the greatest good consequences for the greatest number.
- Requires a comparison of the consequences resulting from different courses of action.

theses of utilitarian theory

two



Hedonism

Only pleasure is good.

- The action chosen should result in pleasure.
 - “Pleasure”: Can also be interpreted as the least pain (*ie*, the ethical action is the one that results in the least pain for the greatest number).

theses of utilitarian theory

three



Maximalism

Greatest pleasure or least pain.

- The action chosen must result in the greatest pleasure or least pain in comparison to all other alternatives.
- An action is right if it results in net pleasure:
 - Net Pleasure = Pleasure > Pain

cost-benefit analysis: a calculation of utility

What is a “cost-benefit analysis”?

- The most precise quantitative method for decision-making: based on monetary costs incurred and benefits accrued from the decision.
- Money is a preferable denominator because it quantifies options that may not otherwise be easily comparable.
- Shadow Pricing: Determining the value reflected by individuals' market and non-market behaviors.

theses of utilitarian theory

four



Universalism

Consider everyone.

- The consequences of the action that we consider should be the consequences of pain and pleasure to everyone.
- Utilitarianism does not require the individual to set aside his/her/their own self-interest; but, the individual's self-interest is equivalent to that of others.

two versions of utilitarianism

there are two versions of utilitarianism:

1. Act Utilitarianism
2. Rule Utilitarianism

which to apply?

It is for you to determine which version is most applicable based on the applicable facts and the ethical dilemma.

neither is better than the other

two versions of utilitarianism

Act Utilitarianism

An Act is Right If & Only If:

it produces the greatest
balance of pleasure over
pain for everyone

Rule Utilitarianism

An Act is Right If & Only If:

it conforms to a set of rules,
the general acceptance of
which would produce the
greatest balance of pleasure
over pain for everyone.

neither is better than the other

let's consider an example

Nick ran a stop light.

let's analyse this by applying act utilitarianism and rule utilitarianism.

act utilitarianism

An act is right if it produces the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone.

act utilitarianism

An act is right if it produces the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone.

Steps:

1. What is the “act” we are analyzing?
2. Who is “everyone”?
3. What are the consequences produced by the “act”?
 - A. What are the pleasurable consequences?
 - B. What are the painful consequences?
4. On balance, did the “act” produce greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?

“nick ran a stop light”

Steps:

1. What is the “act” we are analyzing?
2. Who is “everyone”?
3. What are the consequences produced by the “act”?
 - A. What are the “pleasurable” consequences?
 - B. What are the “painful” consequences?
4. On balance, did the “act” produce greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?

act utilitarianism

Does running a red light produce more pleasure over pain for everyone?

That depends on the consequences of running the right light.

Compare

where you ran a red light as a police officer rushing to the scene of a murder,

vs.

where you ran a red light while drunk and struck a pedestrian.

so, applying act utilitarianism

Nick ran a stop light.

Answer?

Whether this act is ethical pursuant to act utilitarianism is based on the consequences of Nick running the stop light. Just this sentence doesn't give us enough information to determine whether Nick acted ethically or not.

rule utilitarianism

An act is right if and only if it conforms to a set of rules, the general acceptance of which would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone.

rule utilitarianism

An act is right if and only if it conforms to a set of rules, the general acceptance of which would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone.

Steps:

1. What is the “act” we are analyzing?
2. Based on the “act”, what is a rule that we can formulate to analyze whether general acceptance would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone??
3. Consider the rule you have formulated:
 - A. what are the pleasurable consequences for everyone?
 - B. what are the painful consequences for everyone?
4. Would the rule produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?
5. If it would, then all acts that conform to that rule are ethical – analyze the act using this rule.

“nick ran a stop light.”

Steps:

1. What is the “act” we are analyzing?
2. Based on the “act”, what is a rule that we can formulate to analyze whether general acceptance would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?
3. Consider the rule you have formulated:
 - A. what are the pleasurable consequences for everyone?
 - B. what are the painful consequences for everyone?
4. Would the rule produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?
5. If it would, then all acts that conform to that rule are ethical – analyze the act using this rule.

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 1: What is the “act” we are analyzing?

The ethical issue identified is
whether Nick running the stop light is ethical.

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 2: Based on this act, what is a rule we can formulate to analyze whether general acceptance would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?

One possible rule is, “All vehicles can run stop lights.”

Tip: The rule can be anything based on the facts. It is up to you, but must be relevant to determining the ethicality of the act being analyzed.

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 3: Consider the rule you have formulated:

- (a) what are the pleasurable consequences for everyone?**
- (b) what are the painful consequences for everyone?**

We formulated the rule: “All vehicles can run stop lights.”

What are the consequences of this rule?

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 4: On balance, would the rule produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?

We formulated the rule: “All vehicles can run stop lights.”

This rule is not likely to produce the greatest pleasure over pain for everyone.

Tip: Since you need to formulate a rule that would generate the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone, go back to Step 2 and try again.

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 2: Based on this act, what is a rule we can formulate to analyze whether general acceptance would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?

The Original Rule We Formulated:

“All vehicles can run stop lights.”

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 2: Based on this act, what is a rule we can formulate to analyze whether general acceptance would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?

So Let's Formulate a New Rule:

“All vehicles must not run stop lights.”

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 3: Consider the rule you have formulated:

- (a) what are the pleasurable consequences for everyone?**
- (b) what are the painful consequences for everyone?**

We formulated the rule: “All vehicles must not run stop lights.”

What are the consequences of this rule?

“nick ran a stop light.”

Step 4: On balance, would the rule produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone?

We formulated the rule: “All vehicles must not run stop lights.”

This rule is likely to produce the greatest pleasure over pain for everyone.

So, the act should be analyzed by applying this rule.

“nick ran a stop light.”

**Step 5: If it would, then all acts that conform to that rule are ethical –
analyze the act using this rule.**

We formulated the rule: “All vehicles must not run stop lights” and concluded that this rule would produce the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone.

So, if we apply this rule to analyze the act of Nick running a stop light, because his action is counter to the rule, we conclude that under rule utilitarianism, Nick acted unethically.

criticisms of utilitarianism

What do you think of utilitarianism?

Who is "everyone"?

Can we truly calculate utility?

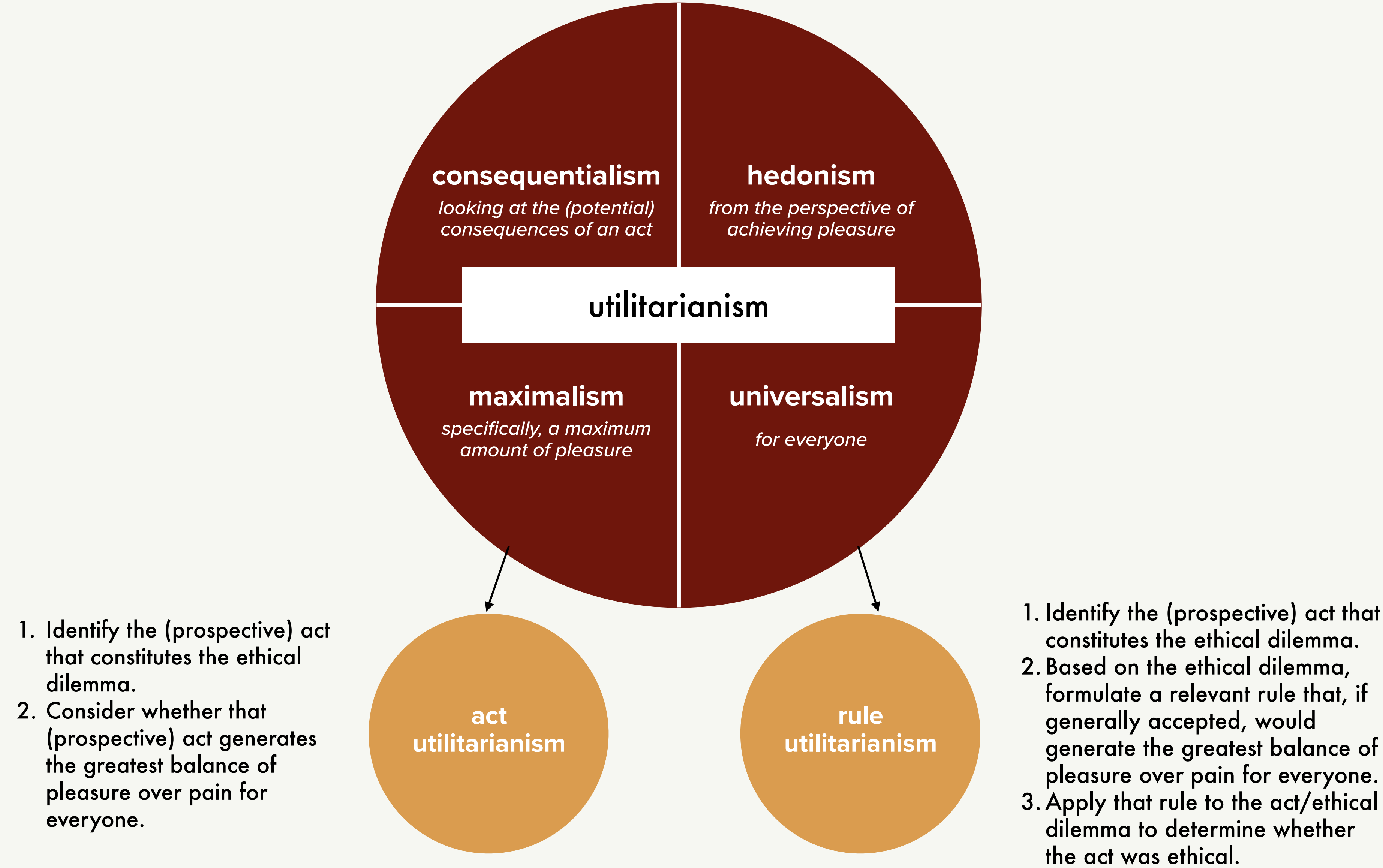
Does everything have a discernible monetary value?

Pleasure and pain - are these subjective?

The extent of pleasure and pain experienced by persons - are these subjective?

Summarising Utilitarianism

in a diagram



doctrine:

An act is ethical if it generates the greatest balance of pleasure over pain for everyone.

criticisms:

Can the consequences of “everyone” be wholly considered?

Subjectivity in pleasure and pain.

Calculations of utility?

Thank
You.

“

Remember to do right this
week.

But, what does “right”
even mean?

—